

company formed formally in 1989 and the SoftMaker Office suite was its key commercial offering. However, due to stiff competition from Windows and other office suite providers its popularity has remained limited to Germany and Europe.

As the company began to face this increasing competition, it shifted its focus to providing new value to the user. This came in the form of full compatibility with dominant file systems while offering users a new, faster, sleeker and more efficient alternative at a cheaper cost. The launch of SoftMaker Office 2012 was the pinnacle of this development process as the company could now provide the top end commercial enterprise level tools at a fraction of the cost and it was also compatible with legacy systems.

The introduction of the SoftMaker FreeOffice was also a part of the company's proliferation strategy as it didn't want to lose out to open source freeware alternatives like OpenOffice.org and LibreOffice. Its greatest selling points are its smaller size, memory impact and faster performance. In addition to this, it offers a visual basic based programming tool as well as an upcoming database application called 'DataMaker'.

Working with SoftMaker FreeOffice 2012

The "best of both worlds" approach adopted by SoftMaker FreeOffice makes it a very compelling option given its free availability and performance. For most users who are limited to using the main applications of word processing, spreadsheet making and presentation creation within an office suite, SoftMaker FreeOffice is a pleasure to use. The key alternatives that SoftMaker competes against are LibreOffice due to the latter's advanced features. Another area where SoftMaker is yet to grow is in the usage of its free version on non-Windows computers since only the professional version also runs on Linux and Android.

Even though most users would recognise FreeOffice as advertising for the professional SoftMaker Office 2012 product, it offers some things that other office suites do not. Unlike LibreOffice, the German software allows you to access the password protected files which have been created on Microsoft Office if you have the password. LibreOffice and other free office suites are yet to include this functionality.

But the greatest feature of SoftMaker FreeOffice is its ability to be installed and launched from a USB drive on any computer. The standard installation of SoftMaker FreeOffice comes with a portable installation option which allows you to carry the suite around in your pocket. With this, you